# “Good Christians don’t have problems.”

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## Where it often comes from

Growing up in a family that hid its problems to look good at church. Hearing testimonies that ended with “and now everything is wonderful.” Being told that troubles mean you are out of God’s will. Feeling ashamed to admit struggles to other believers. A church culture that rewarded looking “fine.”

## What Scripture teaches

Jesus said plainly, “In the world you will have tribulation.” Scripture tells us not to be surprised by fiery trials, as though something strange were happening. Many are the afflictions of the righteous, but the LORD delivers them. Trials are part of the Christian life and can produce perseverance and maturity. Good Christians have problems; what makes them different is where they take their problems.

> *“I have told you these things so that in Me you may have peace. In the world you will have tribulation. But take courage; I have overcome the world!”* **(John 16:33)**.

## Also see

> “Many are the afflictions of the righteous, but the LORD delivers him from them all” **(Psalm 34:19)**.

> “Beloved, do not be surprised at the fiery trial that has come upon you, as though something strange were happening to you. But rejoice that you share in the sufferings of Christ, so that you may be overjoyed at the revelation of His glory” **(1 Peter 4:12–13)**.

> “Consider it pure joy, my brothers, when you encounter trials of many kinds, because you know that the testing of your faith develops perseverance. Allow perseverance to finish its work, so that you may be mature and complete, not lacking anything” **(James 1:2–4)**.

> “Therefore we do not lose heart. Though our outer self is wasting away, yet our inner self is being renewed day by day. For our light and momentary affliction is producing for us an eternal weight of glory that is far beyond comparison” **(2 Corinthians 4:16–17)**.

## Common self-statements

- If I were a better Christian, I wouldn’t have these problems.
- I have to look like I have it all together.
- Other Christians don’t struggle like I do.
- My problems prove I’m failing God.
- I can’t tell anyone at church what’s really going on.
- Real faith makes life easy.

## Common logical errors

- **Should statements:** “A good Christian shouldn’t have problems.”
- **Comparison:** Comparing your real life to other people’s public image.
- **Personalization:** Seeing every problem as proof of personal failure.

- **Mental filter:** Overlooking the many struggles of faithful people in Scripture.

## Challenging questions

- What did Jesus promise about trouble in this world?
- Did the people of faith in the Bible have problems?
- Am I comparing my inside to other people's outside?
- Who taught me to hide my problems?
- What does James say trials can produce?
- What would happen if I were honest with one safe person?
- Is the goal a problem-free life or a faithful one?

## Truth summary

> Good Christians have problems. Jesus said I would have trouble in this world, and He has overcome it. My problems do not prove I am failing God. Trials can grow perseverance and maturity in me. I can be honest about my struggles and bring them to God and to His people.

## Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Troubles
- Hardship
- Suffering
- Hypocritical
- Help

**Godly Counsel Lessons:**

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Trouble/Hardship
- Suffering

## Listen: Overcoming Depression

> **Overcoming Depression** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

*Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"*

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# My Plan for Replacing "Good Christians don't have problems"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

**Name:** _____ **Date started:** _____

## 1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

*Rate it now so you can see your progress later.*

**"Good Christians don't have problems."** I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

## 2 My best question

*The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.*

- ☐ What did Jesus promise about trouble?
- ☐ Did faithful people in the Bible have problems?
- ☐ Am I comparing my inside to others' outside?
- ☐ Who taught me to hide my problems?
- ☐ What can trials produce?
- ☐ Is my goal a problem-free life or a faithful one?

**My own question:** _____

## 3 My replacement truth

*The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.*

- ☐ Good Christians have problems.
- ☐ Jesus has overcome the world.
- ☐ My problems do not prove I am failing God.
- ☐ Trials can grow perseverance in me.
- ☐ I can be honest about my struggles.
- ☐ The LORD delivers the righteous from their afflictions.

**In my own words:** _____

## 4 My Scripture

*The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.*

- [ ] **John 16:33**
  *"I have told you these things so that in Me you may have peace. In the world you will have tribulation. But take courage; I have overcome the world!"*
- [ ] **Psalm 34:19**
  *"Many are the afflictions of the righteous, but the LORD delivers him from them all."*
- [ ] **1 Peter 4:12–13**
  *"Beloved, do not be surprised at the fiery trial that has come upon you, as though something strange were happening to you. But rejoice that you share in the sufferings of Christ, so that you may be overjoyed at the revelation of His glory."*
- [ ] **James 1:2–4**
  *"Consider it pure joy, my brothers, when you encounter trials of many kinds, because you know that the testing of your faith develops perseverance. Allow perseverance to finish its work, so that you may be mature and complete, not lacking anything."*
- [ ] **2 Corinthians 4:16–17**
  *"Therefore we do not lose heart. Though our outer self is wasting away, yet our inner self is being renewed day by day. For our light and momentary affliction is producing for us an eternal weight of glory that is far beyond comparison."*

**A verse I found myself:** _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# Practicing the Truth

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## 5 My practice plan

*Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.*

### EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

### PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Honest log:** Each day, write one real struggle and one way God helped me with it.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Psalm 34:19 becomes: "Many are the afflictions of **Sarah**, but the LORD delivers **her** from them all."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Troubles" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

## 6 My action step this week

*Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.*

- ☐ **Tell one safe Christian about a real struggle** this week, and notice how they respond.
- ☐ **Read about one Bible hero's problems,** such as David, Elijah, or Paul, and write what they faced.
- ☐ **Ask a mature believer:** "What's the hardest thing you've gone through as a Christian?"
- ☐ **Join or visit a small group** where people share honestly and pray for one another.

**What I will do:** _____

**When:** _____

**What the lie predicts will happen:** _____

## 7 End-of-week check-in

*Bring this page to your next session.*

**What actually happened:** _____

What I learned: _____

**The lie** "Good Christians don't have problems": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

## Daily practice tracker

| Day | Read my card | Said my verse | Used my reminder | One struggle I brought to God |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | | | | |
| Tue | | | | |
| Wed | | | | |
| Thu | | | | |
| Fri | | | | |
| Sat | | | | |
| Sun | | | | |

## My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Good Christians don't have problems.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

*Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.*

## Prayer

*Lord Jesus, thank You for telling me the truth: in this world I will have trouble, but You have overcome the world. Help me reject the lie that good Christians don't have problems. Give me courage to be honest, and grow perseverance and faith in me through my trials. In Your name, Amen.*

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*Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.*